anyone.

'If you think it was unfair, you have to ask the director,' he said.

I told him I had approached Gowarikar before coming to him. 'You have to give me a reason,' I insisted.

'Listen Nambi,' Dhawan sighed. 'Again, the reason should be given by the director. Now go back to him.'

I did. But when Gowarikar refused to give a reason, in protest I went on leave.

For me, as it was for many of my colleagues, staying away from work for long was tortuous. I had taken just one day leave for my marriage. My mother had died on a Wednesday (23 November 1966), and I was back at my desk after a couple of days. Kalam and a few colleagues who visited my house on Saturday to offer condolences didn't find me at home—I was at work.

This time I kept away from work frequently, over many months, all the while hoping that Dhawan would do something to get me back to the propulsion team. And then, to my shock, I learned that Gowarikar had got Dhawan's approval before transferring me, for which he had shown a reason. This reason remained unknown to me, but I was sure that if it had to get Dhawan's approval, it had to be serious. I couldn't do this silent protest any longer; soon I found myself at Dhawan's office.

'Sir,' I started. 'Just this: was this done with your approval?'

'Nambi, I told you, it is the director's prerogative to transfer you,' Dhawan replied.

'Sorry, that's not the answer to my question. I asked if you approved it. Give me a yes or no.'

'Yes,' Dhawan said, looking into my eyes.

'Why?'

'Well, there was a corruption charge against you.'

'What was the corruption charge?

'That I don't know.'

Dhawan explained that there was a charge against me, and that he didn't ask for details, and there was no inquiry; and that the director was well within his powers to transfer me to keep me away from such positions where the charge would get aggravated. Fair enough. It was time to get back to Gowarikar.